DO YOU KNOW?

The word 'paper' comes from 'Papyrus'. The Egyptians wrote on the leaves of a plant called papyrus, a kind of reed, which grew on the banks of Nile.

2.3 The Mesopotamian Civilisations

Mesopotamia refers to the region of Iraq and Kuwait in West Asia. Several kingdoms emerged around the city states of this region from the early third millennium BC (BCE). The Sumerian, Akkadian, Babylonian and Assyrian civilisations flourished in Mesopotamia.

Geography

In the Greek language, *meso* means 'in between' and *potamus* means river. The Euphrates and Tigris flow here and drain into the Persian Gulf is since this area is in between two rivers it is known as Mesopotamia. The northern part of Mesopotamia is known as Assyria, and the southern part is called Babylonia.

The Sumerians

The oldest civilisation in Mesopotamia belonged to the Sumerians. The Sumerians were the contemporaries of the people of Indus and the Egyptian civilisations. These civilisations had trade connections. The Sumerians settled in the Lower Tigris valley around 5,000 to 4,000 BC (BCE). They were believed to have originated from Central Asia. They founded many cities and Nippur was one of the important cities. They developed the cuneiform writing system. During the early phase of the Sumerian civilisation, Kings acted as the chief priests. Their political domination came to an end by 2,450 BC (BCE).

The Akkadians

The Akkadians dominated Sumeria briefly from 2450 to 2250 BC (BCE). The S argon o f Akkad was a famous ruler. The Sargon and his descendants (ca.2334–2218 BC (BCE)) ruled Mesopotamia for more than hundred years. In the cuneiform records of Akkadians, mention is made about the Indus civilisation. The documents of the Sargon of Akkad (2334–2279 BC (BCE)) refer to the ships from Meluhha, Magan and Dilmun in the quay of Akkad. Meluhha is identified with Indus vallley.

DO YOU KNOW?

The city of Akkad later became the city of Babylon, a commercial and cultural centre of West Asia.

The Babylonians

The Semitic people called Amorites from the Arabian desert moved into Mesopotamia. They were known as the Babylonians as they



Map of ancient lands of Magan, Dilmun and Meluhha

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